to domestic gain.[15] JFK was clearly sensitive on the matter. In his initial response to US action in the Caribbean, Harold Macmillan wrote: 'I quite understand how fiercely American public opinion will react when it knows these facts.'[16] Kennedy rejoindered: 'I assure you most solemnly that this is not simply a matter of aroused public opinion or of private passion against Cuba,' but, 'so deep a breach in the conventions of the international stalemate that if unchallenged it would deeply shake confidence in the United States, especially in the light of my repeated warnings.'[17]

Concern that acceptance of the missiles would weaken confidence in Washington's commitments to its allies in the region and in Europe was expressed by various members of ExComm. Most obvious, the security of West Berlin rested on Soviet calculations about how far Kennedy would risk a wider conflagration. In his speech in July 1961, the President had said, 'we have given our word that an attack upon that city will be regarded as an attack upon us all.' In September 1962 he made clear that 'offensive' weapons would not be accepted in Cuba. If his words meant nothing ninety miles from US shores, what might the Soviets believe they meant over 4,000 miles away in Berlin? Naftali and Zelikow argue that if JFK did not insist on the removal of the missiles, Khrushchev would be emboldened on West Berlin, and Kennedy:

> would either have to abandon the two and a half million West Berliners, theretofore protected by the United States, or he would have to use nuclear weapons against the Soviet Union, for there was no imaginable way of defending West Berlin with conventional military forces. The Soviet missiles in Cuba would be a 'knife in our guts' constraining the U.S. nuclear threats to save Berlin.[18]

How, then, were the missiles to be removed? Maxwell Taylor later summed up the options: 'Take then out … squeeze them out … buy them out.'[19] There were also various diplomatic options that involved confronting Khrushchev (or Castro) in private with the news the missiles had been discovered. There was little support within ExComm, though as the